

HOST GUIDE / The Last Acquisition

Your role

Host a museum gala and lead the investigation into Grant Larceny's death. You can play too: the murderer is chosen by a secret memorized animal draw, and this guide reveals no character's private branch.

Object of the game

Before Coming Clean, identify the murderer and connect their motive with the salon, cabinet key and linen evidence. Guests can read every question and answer directly from their own packet; acting is optional.

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Party details

October 30, 2026 / 1537 S 74th East Ave, Tulsa, OK 74112. Plan 6:00 arrival to 9:30 finish. Assign the first 15 roles before adding more guests. Every attending character can be the murderer.

Preparation checklist

One week before

- Assign character names and send each guest only their public introduction PDF or PNG and invitation.
- Ask guests to remember their character names. Nobody needs a character number or a partner. Costume ideas are optional.
- Read this guide and choose who will deliver the investigation announcements. If playing, keep private packet pages and organizer sources unread.
- Choose rooms for the museum labels and print one complete packet per attending guest.

Before guests arrive

- Staple each twelve-page packet in order. Put a pencil and named place card with it. The ballot and Coming Clean are already inside.
- Print the host name checklist. Put the five reports F1-F5 in order in a host folder.
- Hide Discoveries 1-16 using page 8. Set an Evidence Table.
- Prepare Player Bowl A and matching Murderer Bowl B using all 30 familiar animals, plus one closed return box.
- Lower the music for questioning. Guests may sit anywhere; no partner assignment is needed.

Materials and copy counts

Item	Copies / purpose
Complete twelve-page packet	One per attending guest; questions, records, ballot and Coming Clean included
Host guide and name checklist	One each
Public introduction PDF or PNG	One sent to each guest before the party
F1-F5 investigation reports	One staged set, read aloud and displayed
Discoveries 1-16	One hidden set
Animal draw cards	Two matching sets of 30 animals
Containers	Bowl A, matching Bowl B, closed return box
Place cards, signs, exhibits, awards	One set as needed
Pencils	One per guest; spares

Printing

Single-sided, Actual size / 100%. Staple packets. No font installation is needed. Use a non-playing helper if your printer exposes private text. No player question catalog, evidence-letter cards or finale envelopes are required.

Character directory

Assign by personality

Assign the first fifteen names before adding the remaining roles. Names are how guests choose questions and vote. Animals are drawn privately at arrival; every attending role is eligible.

Artie Ficial	Executive Director of the Meridian Museum
Claire O'Scuro	Chief Curator of World Cultures
Hugh Bidder	International Art Dealer & Collector Liaison
Monet Bags	Chief Financial Officer of the Meridian Museum
Chip Patina	Chief Conservator
Dada DiCapo	Performance Artist & Cultural Celebrity
Vincent Van Faux	Celebrated Contemporary Painter
Sue Venir	Cultural Property Attorney
Dr. Art E. Fact	Professor of Art History & Provenance Scholar
Tess Tament	Philanthropist & Heir to the Larceny Family Fortune
Barb Dwyer	Director of Museum Security & Former Art-Crimes Investigator
Paige Turner	Investigative Arts Journalist
Frank Lloyd Wrong	Exhibition Architect & Designer
Mona Lott	International Cultural Heritage Envoy
Elon Mosaic	Tech Founder, Collector & Museum Patron

Character directory

Assign by personality

Assign the first fifteen names before adding the remaining roles. Names are how guests choose questions and vote. Animals are drawn privately at arrival; every attending role is eligible.

Anya Tique	Founding Curator Emerita
Saul D. Bid	Chairman of Gavel & Rowe Auction House
Elle Loominate	Textile Artist & Designer
Reed DeLabel	Doctoral Fellow in Art History
Al Baster	Sculptor & Public-Art Star
Ella Gance	Collector, Style Patron & Society Fixture
Drew Conclusions	Art Critic & Cultural Podcaster
Brie DeVivre	Head Caterer & Hospitality Director
Cary Crates	Senior Art Handler & Installation Specialist
Anne E. Dote	Director of Education & Docent Programs
Faye Stop	Gala Photographer & Editorial Portraitist
Robin Banks	Cultural Restitution Activist & Nonprofit Organizer
Penny Pincher	Eccentric Private Collector
Justin Tyme	Tulsa Arts Columnist & Local Historian
Minnie Malist	Gala Event Designer & Creative Producer

Memorized animal assignment

At arrival

- Each guest draws one animal from Bowl A, reads silently, memorizes it, folds the slip and immediately returns it to the closed box. Nobody keeps or shows a slip.
- Draw only from Bowl A. Never put returned slips back into A during arrivals.
- When all expected guests have drawn, remove from matching Bowl B every unused animal left in A. B now contains exactly the animals memorized by attending guests.
- There is no optional bowl and no name-to-animal list. Keep B separate from the closed return box.

After Act I

Ask everyone to keep a blank face. Draw one animal from Bowl B and announce it twice. The guest who memorized it uses IF MURDERER; everyone else uses IF INNOCENT. Keep the selected animal in the host folder for the Coming Clean fallback. Do not identify its owner now.

Late arrivals

A guest arriving after selection may draw an unused A animal and join as innocent: that animal was excluded from B. Before selection, simply include their draw in the normal attendance process.

Print and assemble complete packets

One packet per guest

- Print the named SECRET file as one twelve-page packet, face down. Keep pages in order and staple at the left.
- Page 1: private background and social tasks. Pages 2–4: Motive. Pages 5–7: Opportunity. Pages 8–10: Method. Page 11: ballot. Page 12: Coming Clean.
- Each round has two question pages followed by one answer page. All packets include every target name and the grouped questions.
- No cutting or selecting letter cards. No shared question catalog. No separately sealed finale. The final page stays unread until the host calls it.

Combined printing

If using the combined file, each consecutive twelve-page block is one character's complete packet. Follow the names on the cover and the public assembly sheet. Never distribute the combined file to guests.

Host folder

F1–F2 before Motive; F3 before Opportunity; F4–F5 before Method. Keep staged reports separate from the sixteen hidden discoveries.

06 / Clue placement / Discoveries 1–16

1	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Inside or beneath a folder
2	Viv office / Registrar	Behind a binder or clipboard
3	Bathroom / Patron Lounge	Near the mirror or folded hand towel
4	Media room / Archives	Inside a magazine or program
5	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Beside cleaning or craft supplies
6	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Under a legal-size envelope
7	Living room / Grand Gallery	Inside an exhibition catalogue
8	Living room / Grand Gallery	Behind a frame or display card
9	Dining room / Founders Hall	Under an education-program brochure
10	Dalmo office / Donor Salon	Near the room sign or faux security note
11	Media room / Archives	Inside an old-looking notebook
12	Living room / Grand Gallery	Beside an art label or sketch
13	Laundry / Conservation Lab	Under a condition-report clipboard
14	Guest bedroom / Silk Road Gallery	Attached to or inside a prop crate/box
15	Media room / Archives	Near the TV/projector/lighting controls
16	Kitchen / Sculpture Court	Near the buffet/service area

When a clue is found

Ask the finder to bring it to the Evidence Table and read it to nearby guests. Record finds for Curator's Eye. Missing discoveries do not delay the guided investigation.

Evening agenda

6:00–6:20	Arrival, memorize and return animals
6:20–6:55	Act I: introductions, social tasks, discoveries
6:55–7:05	Buffet; gather in the speaking area
7:05–7:10	Death announcement and murderer animal draw
7:10–7:30	Motive: F1–F2; each guest answers
7:30–8:00	Opportunity: F3; each guest answers
8:00–8:30	Method: F4–F5; answers include records
8:30–8:45	Open discussion and deductions
8:45–8:55	Private ballots; collect and lock votes
8:55–9:15	Top three Coming Clean; confession if needed
9:15–9:30	Awards, dessert, debrief

Keep the group moving

These are planning allowances, not measured performance times. Read one question and one answer per guest per round. With 30 guests, avoid extra speeches until everyone has answered. Pause for a short discussion after each round.

Act I / Welcome and gossip

Say aloud

Welcome to the Meridian Museum gala. Introduce yourself by your character name, then open only Private background. Your three social tasks are invitations to chat. If a named guest is absent, discuss that subject with anyone. Bring discoveries to the Evidence Table.

Run Act I

- Invite each guest to give their character name and role. Their public introduction is enough.
- Allow mingling, social tasks and discovery hunting. No improvisation or task completion is required to solve the murder.
- Ask finders to share the actual document or photograph they found and award one discovery point.
- Near the end, gather everyone, turn down the music and announce Grant's death. Select and announce the murderer animal using page 6.
- Say: Read only the current round. Your final Coming Clean page is for after voting.

Investigation / Motive

Release and announce

Read F1 / Toxicology and F2 / Grant's unfinished business aloud and display the complete report. Say: Open Motive. Questions are on pages 2-3; your answer is on page 4. Choose by character name, not a number.

Question chain

- Choose a starting guest. They pick someone who has not answered yet from an ASK row in their packet and read that row's question.
- The named guest reads the appropriate answer box on their Motive answer page, keeping the label private. Several names share a question, but their answers are different.
- That guest becomes the next asker and chooses another unanswered person by name. No seating order or partner assignment.
- Tick each respondent's name on the checklist. The starting guest must answer too; have the final respondent ask them if needed.
- Ignore absent names. If someone chooses a guest already heard, quietly offer an unanswered name from the same question pages.
- When every guest has answered once, stop the chain and invite a short discussion. Then announce Opportunity.

If a guest needs help

A neighbour may read only the box the guest points to. Do not ask which branch they selected. For Method, the preparation record is inside the answer box and is read aloud with it.

Investigation / Opportunity

Release and announce

Read F3 / Salon timeline and steward statement aloud and display the complete report. Say: Open Opportunity. Questions are on pages 5-6; your answer is on page 7. Choose by character name, not a number.

Question chain

- Choose a starting guest. They pick someone who has not answered yet from an ASK row in their packet and read that row's question.
- The named guest reads the appropriate answer box on their Opportunity answer page, keeping the label private. Several names share a question, but their answers are different.
- That guest becomes the next asker and chooses another unanswered person by name. No seating order or partner assignment.
- Tick each respondent's name on the checklist. The starting guest must answer too; have the final respondent ask them if needed.
- Ignore absent names. If someone chooses a guest already heard, quietly offer an unanswered name from the same question pages.
- When every guest has answered once, stop the chain and invite a short discussion. Then announce Method.

If a guest needs help

A neighbour may read only the box the guest points to. Do not ask which branch they selected. For Method, the preparation record is inside the answer box and is read aloud with it.

Investigation / Method

Release and announce

Read F4 / Cabinet audit and F5 / Fiber comparison aloud and display the complete report. Say: Open Method. Questions are on pages 8-9; your answer is on page 10. Choose by character name, not a number.

Question chain

- Choose a starting guest. They pick someone who has not answered yet from an ASK row in their packet and read that row's question.
- The named guest reads the appropriate answer box on their Method answer page, keeping the label private. Several names share a question, but their answers are different.
- That guest becomes the next asker and chooses another unanswered person by name. No seating order or partner assignment.
- Tick each respondent's name on the checklist. The starting guest must answer too; have the final respondent ask them if needed.
- Ignore absent names. If someone chooses a guest already heard, quietly offer an unanswered name from the same question pages.
- When every guest has answered once, stop the chain and invite a short discussion. Then announce voting.

If a guest needs help

A neighbour may read only the box the guest points to. Do not ask which branch they selected. For Method, the preparation record is inside the answer box and is read aloud with it.

Voting and Coming Clean

Collect and lock ballots

- Ask everyone to complete page 11 privately: one accused character, motive and evidence, plus award votes. The murderer votes too.
- Collect every ballot before anyone opens Coming Clean. No votes change after collection.
- Tally by character name. Select the three highest positive vote totals, or fewer if fewer names received votes. Break equal totals alphabetically by full character name, so there are at most three suspects.
- Read the three names aloud in descending vote order. Call each one to read only their IF INNOCENT or IF MURDERER Coming Clean box on page 12. All three get their statement, even if a confession is heard early.

If nobody confesses

Say: The murderer is not among our three suspects. Whoever memorized [selected animal], please stand and read your IF MURDERER Coming Clean confession. Do not call the animal if one of the three already confessed.

Award and finish

Master Sleuth: correct murderer, motive and a coherent salon/key/linen explanation. Share equally strong detective awards. Escaped Justice: murderer outside the top three. Use ballot votes for Best Actor and Best Costume; discovery tally for Curator's Eye. Then debrief over dessert.

Quick cues and troubleshooting

Welcome	Introductions / private background / social tasks / discoveries
Select	Memorize and return / exclude unused A from B / announce animal
Motive	F1-F2 / pages 2-4 / named question chain / tick everyone
Opportunity	F3 / pages 5-7 / named question chain / tick everyone
Method	F4-F5 / pages 8-10 / answer plus records / tick everyone
Vote	Discuss / page 11 / collect every ballot / no changes
Coming Clean	Page 12 / top three / animal fallback only if no confession
Finish	Awards / dessert / debrief

Recovery

- Forgotten animal before selection: restart the draw for everyone. No identity list and no guessing.
- Forgotten animal after selection: pause; never guess the murderer. Restart assignments only if all guests can do so, otherwise postpone scoring.
- Absent guest: skip their name. Remove their unused animal from B before selection.
- Duplicate target: offer an unanswered name. If the chain loses track, the host may ask an unanswered guest directly from the same printed group questions.
- Reading ahead: stop before Coming Clean is read aloud. Return to the current round; page 12 opens only after ballots are collected.
- Missing packet page: replace the complete named packet. Do not hand a guest a standalone branch.